

Fragments of Fragments of Fragments of

or: How Anne Carson Uses Lacking in *Autobiography of Red*

Identity is difficult to define. It resides in detached, associated pieces inside the ‘red dawn jelly’ of the mind. In *Autobiography of Red*, Anne Carson explores the fragments of Stesichoros; she turns a few torn scraps of a poem into the life of the red monster, Geryon, and sprawls out his autobiography across three primary formats. A strange and circular iteration of Greek dialectic reasoning, a fictional semiautobiographical romance novel in verse, and photographic essays based on photos taken by the main character. These elements are pasted into the novel in parataxis. Carson lets the pull of their poetic magnetism hold the book together as they weigh on each other, never giving us the satisfying: snap! The paratactic nature of writing about fragments is reflected in the structure of the work, jumping between appendices and abrupt chapters without warning. The larger themes of the work are complex and multivalent, but this essay will focus on the fragmented nature of human relationships and self-identity, and the role lacking plays in their development through the lens of paratactic structure and syntax. Carson explores the ways humans have tried to hold onto the pieces of identity and relationships: finding inadequacy in the circular logic of dialectic reasoning, stillness in the moment of a photograph, and life in the form of a romance.

Carson is a classicist, translator, and poet. But not in that order. The book opens with a brief introduction about Stesichoros and three appendices, the third of which is “Clearing up the question of Stesichoros’ blinding by Helen” (18). The appendix takes the form of an experimental, comical, and strangely circular line of dialectic reasoning. The structure starts with a statement, “1. Either Stesichoros was a blind man or he was not”. Two things are immediate and apparent in this sentence: the claim is circular, and punctuation is not present. The conditional phrase is typical of Greek dialectic reasoning and follows the grammatical structure of many lines of reasoning. The

twenty statements that follow maintain a specific structure: ‘If A, either B or C.’ then ‘If B, either D or E’ and so forth. Though the form is never broken during this sequence, a strange departure happens during statements 8 and 9:

8. If it was a strong remark about Helen’s sexual misconduct (not to say its unsavory aftermath the Fall of Troy) either this remark was a lie or it was not.

9. If it was not a lie either we are now in reverse and by continuing to reason in this way are likely to arrive back at the beginning of the question of the blinding of Stesichoros or we are not. (19)

Carson frequently uses the technique of imposing a structure on her writing to intentionally break or distort it. First, the parenthetical statement is an interjection in a line of reasoning, distorting the form in a humorous way. Second, the lack of a comma before ‘the Fall of Troy’ is a hallmark of Carson’s writing, as her heavy use of appositive, parataxis, and omission of comma blends verse and prose into a stream of consciousness uniquely in her voice. Statement nine is where Carson plays with the impossibility of determining the truth of the original statement by making the form of dialectics shoot itself in the foot. The sentence spreads out, stating how “we are now in reverse”, a confusing statement that includes the reader in the line of reasoning, and moves closer to a narrative. The confusion continues as the sentences runs on through the rest of the correlated phrases, Carson continues, “and by continuing to reason in this way are likely to arrive back at the beginning of the question of the blinding of Stesichoros”. The comically long chain of prepositional phrases starts the process of obfuscation, we see “by continuing”, “to reason”, “in this way”, “at the beginning”, “of the question”, “of the blinding”, “of Stesichoros” all as the first half of the statement. The second half of the clause is simply “or we are not”. The convolution of the sentence

intertwines with the fruitless chain of statements that ultimately cannot answer the question of Stesichoros' blinding. The fundamental idea of lacking comes through both in the function and the form, as when omissions are made and questions are left unanswered, we are forced both to consider the gap that is left behind, and to fill in the gap for ourselves. By returning to dialectic reasoning, Carson addresses how even the foundations of logic and language are unable to take the leap of assumption needed to connect the pieces of humanity. This technique challenges the categorizations of genre and form and engages with the themes of self-identity and relationships in the book. Carson explores the impossible nature of staying true to the original text of a fragment, just as the character of Geryon in the novel that follows finds it impossible to stay true to an identity that is built of small, shattered pieces.

The next approach Carson takes to explore fragmentation and lacking is the story of Geryon. A novel, a romance, and a coming-of-age story, this section of the book branches through styles of verse and prose, dialogue, free indirect discourse, and differing voice. Both the character of Geryon and his story are built upon a lacking. Lack of a mother's affection, a father, a brother's love, a lover, and an identity. As Geryon has to assemble his own identity, we too have to assemble what the story means to us through the pieces we are provided. Much of Carson's language through this section draws on absence and fragmentation, as early in the story we see Geryon's autobiography include a phone call his mother had:

Yes dear I know it doesn't matter now

. . . .

Geryon? fine he's right here working on his autobiography

. . . .

No it's a sculpture he doesn't know how to write yet

....

Oh this and that stuff he finds outside Geryon's always finding things aren't you Geryon?

Only including one side of the conversation is another form of lacking Carson employs, fragmented pieces of a conversation that we only have access to one side of. The lack of commas also draws on the natural flow of conversation and thought, the pacing and purpose can't be slowed down by punctuation. The content of the conversation is also relevant to the themes being exemplified by it, as the construction of Geryon's autobiography begins with him trying to build a sculpture of himself, a literal building of self-identity that takes place before he has the tools of language to express who he is to the reader. The nature of the narration is strange, as it takes a third-person omniscient approach, but is rooted in the autobiographical memories of Geryon. We see a more pronounced perspective coming through when the narration is more clearly connected to Geryon's own developed voice. This voice is brought forward when Geryon visits his emotionally distant mother later in the narrative, Carson brings us into the mind of Geryon:

He had taken the local bus from Hades. Seven-hour trip. He wept most of the way wanted to go straight to his room and shut the door but when he saw her he sat down. Hands in his jacket... Eyes on his chest. (68)

The fragmented interjections of descriptive language squeezed between action are a perfect capturing of thought. The associative lurches to either side as Geryon remembers or considers events are comedic, as the ellipses of verbs turn the fragments into adjectival descriptors. Pardon the redundancy, but the importance of sentence fragments as fragments in other senses is an intentional and carefully constructed idea in this section of the book. This chapter takes place in a moment when Geryon visits his mother and notes the emptiness of a fruit bowl in their house. The

awkwardness of their conversation shows the lack of emotional connection they have, the emptiness of the fruit bowl shows a lack of fruit, and the heavy use of parataxis shows Geryon's lack of language to describe these missing pieces. We see parataxis all through the chapter: "[Geryon] began spinning the fruit bowl slowly. He spun it clockwise. Counterclockwise. Clockwise" (68), "finally they rose and went their ways. The fruit bowl stayed there. Yes empty" (69). The syntax asks us to read between the lines, the fragments of clockwise and counterclockwise capture the momentary nature of the action through adjective, not needing to be drawn out by a verb or an actor. The quick succession of statements punctuated only by periods feels very brief and emotionless, but the final words of the chapter, "Yes empty" is an exclamation coming from outside the perspective of the main character, separate from dialogue, almost as if Carson is leading us to ask the question: "*How do we even know it's a fruit bowl?*" (68). This question leads us to consider, is a fruit bowl that lacks fruit even a fruit bowl? Is a mother that doesn't nurture her children even a mother? Is a relationship without love even a relationship? Does someone who doesn't know their identity even have one? The way Carson poses the largest questions of the novel via omission is a powerful use of language and form, the box of fragments the story was found in is reflected perfectly in the work, as the reader is left to consider what is left out. Full of associative interjections, tactful appositive, and broad-sweeping brush strokes of parataxis, Carson wants us to consider the ambiguous nature of an autobiography, with all its lapses and forgotten details. The characters of the story often grapple with these ideas inside the narrative as well, turning to photography to capture what words cannot. Photography becomes an important representation of capturing moments in light and time, or a foothold jutting out from the loose sliding tumble of memory.

The final chapters of the autobiographical novel take the form of photographic essays. Each one contains a brief description of the photograph on the page, then an essay portraying the moment that surrounds the photograph. The stylization that takes place during this final section is

the culmination of all the omission, fragmentation, and parataxis that fills the narrative preceding. Each chapter lies independently of one another, more akin to a scrapbook than a novel. In this section we see a shift in Geryon's self-identity through the photographs he takes. Earlier in the novel we saw photographs described as a capturing of light, a compression of a moment on a motionless surface (51). But not long before the photographs, Geryon "was memorizing the zebra so he could make a photograph later" (115). The idea that a photograph is made by a photographer, not taken, is a commentary on context, on what is missing from a photograph. In the photographic essays, we get to see into Geryon's perspective in the moments surrounding the photograph, as if accessing his memory while viewing the photo. Narratively, the photographs take place at the end of a journey, a journey towards a volcano, self-discovery, and love. In "Photographs: like and not like" (142), an argument happens without words, a physical fight breaks out, and Geryon is pushed towards an identity with a forcible velocity. As one of the last fragmented moments of his being, Geryon is told, "*There is one thing I want from you. / Yes. / Want to see you use those wings.* A silence tossed itself across the tall gold heads of the fennel stalks between them. Into this silence burst Herakles" (144). Here the fragmented language of "want to see you use those wings" comes from a character speaking to Geryon, using ellipses of a pronoun. In contrast to this, the narration about Geryon reforms into full, meticulous, poetic sentences. "A silence" used as a subject to be tossed across something, "the tall gold heads of the fennel stalks between them" as a direct object, full of prepositions, but with purpose. The narrative voice regains a composure, becomes a more solidified and consistent force within the book as Geryon creates a more concrete identity. When Carson chooses very carefully when and where to omit, or rather when not to omit, the moments stand out. This single sentence shows a development in Geryon's character through its balanced and poetic movement, only to be interrupted as "Into this silence burst Herakles". The next photograph, "# 1748", is a pivotal moment in the narrative where Geryon uses his wings and flies above the volcano, both of which

are symbols for his self-identity through the novel. The chapter title is a reference back to the Emily Dickinson poem that epigraphs the novel, as well as the moments leading to its end:

He has not flown for years but why not be a black speck raking its way toward the crater of Icchantikas on icy possibles, why not rotate the inhuman Andes at a personal angle and retreat when it spins—if it does and if not, win bolts of wind like slaps of wood and the bitter red drumming of wing muscle on air—he flicks Record. *This is for Ancash*, he calls to the earth diminishing below. This is a memory of our beauty. He peers down at the earth heart of Icchantikas dumping all its photons out her ancient eye and he smiles for the camera: “The Only Secret People Keep”. (145)

The momentous shift in the narrative that takes place here is also accompanied by an amazing shift in style. It takes the two styles of narration associated with Geryon: the short, fragmented slices of emotion through parataxis that pervade throughout the novel, and the long and complex sentences of poetic beauty that rise from his growth, and twists them together like wrought iron. From the beginning we see the lack of commas intertwined with a series of questions that lack question marks. The entire first sentence branches out from “he has not flown for years”, rising with a flight-like velocity, sparing no moments for question marks, commas, or periods. The series of questions raise a powerful tension as they pour down the page, stopped abruptly by an interjection. This interjection’s structure starts with the conditional “if it does and if not”, a conditional which doesn’t actually apply a condition, which then sprawls out into a simile of powerful prepositions: “bolts of wind like slaps of wood”, “the bitter red drumming of wing muscle on air”. This moment is a perfect reversal of Geryon’s language from earlier in the novel, in which fragments of sentences represented a lacking of something; now they are piled here, sliding back and forth, in and out of each other with too much emotion and imagery to be contained inside of them. They can only

appear as short bursts culminating in when “he flicks Record”. We also see this reversal with the series of prepositions, as before they were used to convolute purpose, they now hold a deep complexity of image and represent the formation of Geryon’s identity in a moment where he reclaims the fractured, fragmented nature of his own composition. Through the masterful blending of these techniques Carson shows Geryon’s identity form before us, held in “a memory of our beauty”.

The roles of fragmentation and lacking in character development are explored not only through the plot of the book, but also the structure as well. The detached segments of the book, full of paratactic language that continually reinforce these themes. Carson plays with the push and pull of memory and language, showing their weaknesses and complexity through omission. We see the overwhelming moments of emotion escape from the mind in long, trailing sentences, curt lines of emotions shut out, and perspective flowing in and out of time, place, and voice. The masterful application of language portrays Geryon’s complex and scatterbrained construction of identity. It is dumped out of the box of scraps by Carson through parataxis and complex stylistic patterns. These elements fuse and culminate in the profound and confusing work that is *Autobiography of Red*. Gladys!

Works Cited

Carson, Anne. *AUTOBIOGRAPHY OF RED*. Random House, 1999.

